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Managing Anger for Kids

Help your child understand, express, and control big emotions in healthy ways

NeuroKids™

Table of Contents

Introduction: Understanding Anger 3

Section 1 — Recognizing Anger 4

1.1 Anger Triggers Worksheet 5

1.2 Body Signals of Anger 6

1.3 Anger Intensity Scale 7

1.4 Emotion Faces to Identify 8

1.5 Anger Diary Page 9

Section 2 — Cooling Down Strategies 10

2.1 Cool-Down Choice Wheel 11

2.2 Deep Breathing Cards 12

2.3 Counting Backwards Exercise 13

2.4 Safe Space Design Sheet 14

2.5 Anger Iceberg Worksheet 15

Section 3 — Expressing Feelings 16

3.1 Feelings Vocabulary Cards 17

3.2 “I Feel… Because…” Starters 18

3.3 Emotion Charades Cards 19

3.4 Draw Your Anger Exercise 20

3.5 Letter to My Anger 21

Section 4 — Problem Solving 22

4.1 Conflict Resolution Steps 23

4.2 Win-Win Solution Finder 24

4.3 Apology Template 25

4.4 Empathy Building Cards 26

My Anger Management Plan 27

Closing & Next Step 28

INTRO

Understanding Anger

Anger is normal — and learning to handle it is a superpower

> *Everyone gets angry sometimes — kids, parents, teachers, even your favorite cartoon characters. Anger is a completely normal human emotion. It is your brain's way of telling you that something feels unfair, scary, or frustrating. There is nothing wrong with feeling angry. What matters is what you do when anger shows up.*

Did You Know?

Anger is one of the six basic emotions that every person in the world experiences. Scientists have found that even babies can feel angry! It is a built-in part of being human.

Think of anger like a fire alarm. A fire alarm is not a bad thing — it is trying to protect you by telling you something important. But if you let the alarm keep ringing without doing anything helpful, it can become really loud and overwhelming. Learning to manage anger means knowing how to hear the alarm, understand the message, and then choose a smart response.

In this workbook, you will:

Learn to **recognize** your anger — what triggers it and how it feels in your body.
Discover **cooling-down strategies** that actually work.
Practice **expressing your feelings** with words, pictures, and actions.
Build **problem-solving skills** so you can handle tough situations.
Create your very own **Anger Management Plan** that you can use anytime, anywhere.

A Note for Kids

This workbook is yours. There are no wrong answers. You can write in it, draw in it, and color in it. Take your time with each activity. If something feels hard, that is okay — it means your brain is growing stronger!

1

Recognizing Anger

Learn to spot anger before it takes over

> *The first step in managing anger is recognizing it. When you can name it, you can tame it! In this section, you will discover what makes you angry, how your body reacts, and how strong your anger can get.*

1.1 — Anger Triggers Worksheet

An **anger trigger** is something that makes you feel angry. Look at the common triggers below. Put a check next to the ones that make *you* angry, then add your own at the bottom.

TRIGGER	☐	HOW ANGRY DOES IT MAKE ME? (1–5)
Someone takes my things without asking	☐	
Being told “no” when I really want something	☐	
Someone calls me a name or makes fun of me	☐	
Losing at a game or competition	☐	
Being left out by friends	☐	
Having to stop doing something fun	☐	
Someone breaking a promise	☐	
Being blamed for something I didn’t do	☐	
Not being listened to	☐	
Homework or schoolwork that feels too hard	☐	
A sibling bothering me	☐	
Things not going the way I planned	☐	

My own triggers:

> **Reflection**
>
> Which trigger gets you the most angry? Circle it. Knowing your biggest trigger is the first step to being ready for it!

1.2 — Body Signals of Anger

When you get angry, your body sends signals. Read about each body part below, then **circle or color** the ones you notice in yourself when you are angry.

Head / Forehead

You might feel hot or like your head is "going to explode." Your face may turn red. Some kids get headaches.

Eyes

Your eyes might squint or feel like they are staring hard. Some kids feel tears starting, because anger and sadness can mix together.

Jaw / Mouth

You may clench your jaw tight or grind your teeth. Some kids press their lips together really hard.

Shoulders / Neck

Your shoulders might rise up toward your ears and feel really tight and stiff, like you are carrying a heavy backpack.

Chest / Heart

Your heart may beat faster and harder. It might feel like a drum pounding inside your chest.

Stomach

You might get a stomachache, feel sick, or have "butterflies" — but the kind that do not feel good.

Hands / Fists

Your hands may clench into fists. Some kids feel tingling or shaking in their fingers.

Legs / Feet

You might feel like stomping, kicking, or running away. Your legs may feel tense and jittery.

The body signal I notice most is:

Another signal I sometimes feel:

1.3 — Anger Intensity Scale

Anger comes in different sizes. Not every angry moment is the same. Use this scale to figure out how angry you are. Write what each level feels like for *you*.

1 **Slightly Annoyed** — Something small bothers you, but you can let it go easily. Like a tiny pebble in your shoe.
For me, Level 1 feels like:

2 **Irritated** — You feel grumpy and annoyed. It is harder to ignore. Like a mosquito buzzing around your head.
For me, Level 2 feels like:

3 **Frustrated** — You feel hot and tense. Your body is starting to react. Like a pot of water that is starting to bubble.
For me, Level 3 feels like:

4 **Very Angry** — You feel like yelling, crying, or hitting. It is really hard to think clearly. Like a thunderstorm inside you.
For me, Level 4 feels like:

5 **Explosive** — You feel completely out of control. You might say or do things you regret. Like a volcano erupting.
For me, Level 5 feels like:

> **Important**
>
> The goal is not to never reach Level 5. The goal is to notice when you are at Level 2 or 3 so you can use a strategy *before* you reach 4 or 5. The earlier you notice, the easier it is to calm down!

1.4 — Emotion Faces to Identify

Anger has many cousins. Read each emotion below, then check the box if you have felt it before and write when you feel that way.

Angry

Feeling mad because something is unfair or wrong.

☐ I feel this when:

Frustrated

Feeling stuck because something is not working out.

☐ I feel this when:

Annoyed

Feeling bothered by something small that keeps happening.

☐ I feel this when:

Furious

Feeling extremely angry, like you might explode.

☐ I feel this when:

Irritated

Feeling slightly angry, like something is getting on your nerves.

☐ I feel this when:

Mad

Feeling upset and wanting the situation to change right now.

☐ I feel this when:

Jealous

Feeling angry because someone has something you want.

☐ I feel this when:

Disappointed

Feeling let down because something did not happen the way you hoped.

☐ I feel this when:

> **Think About It**
>
> Which of these emotions do you feel most often? Being able to name the exact feeling helps your brain calm down faster. Scientists call this “name it to tame it!”

1.5 — Anger Diary Page

Use this page to track an angry moment. You can photocopy this page and use it every time you get angry. Writing about it helps your brain process the emotion.

DATE: _____

WHAT HAPPENED?

Describe the situation. Who was there? What was going on?

HOW ANGRY WAS I? (CIRCLE ONE)

1 2 3 4 5

WHAT BODY SIGNALS DID I NOTICE?

WHAT DID I DO WHEN I FELT ANGRY?

DID IT HELP? ☐ YES ☐ NO ☐ A LITTLE

WHAT COULD I TRY NEXT TIME?

2

Cooling Down Strategies

Tools you can use to turn down the heat

> *Now that you know how to recognize anger, it is time to learn what to do about it. These strategies are like tools in a toolbox — different tools work for different situations. Try them all and find your favorites!*

2.1 — Cool-Down Choice Wheel

Here are eight proven strategies that kids can use to cool down. Read each one, then put a star next to the three you want to try first.

1

COUNT TO 10

Slowly count from 1 to 10. Take a breath between each number. This gives your brain time to switch from “react mode” to “think mode.” If 10 is not enough, try counting to 20.

2

WALK AWAY

Remove yourself from the situation. Go to another room, step outside, or find a quiet corner. Walking uses up the extra energy that anger creates in your body.

3

SQUEEZE A STRESS BALL

Squeeze something soft — a stress ball, a pillow, or even a rolled-up sock. Squeeze hard for 5 seconds, then release. Repeat 5 times. This releases the tension in your muscles.

4

DRAW YOUR FEELINGS

Grab paper and crayons and draw what your anger looks like. Use colors, shapes, and lines. You do not have to draw anything specific — just let the feelings flow onto the paper.

5

DRINK COLD WATER

Take slow sips of cold water. Focus on how the water feels going down your throat. This activates your body’s calming system and gives you a moment to pause.

6

TALK TO SOMEONE

Find a trusted person — a parent, teacher, friend, or sibling — and tell them how you feel. Sometimes just saying “I feel really angry right now” helps the feeling shrink.

7

BREATHE DEEPLY

Take a slow, deep breath in through your nose for 4 counts. Hold it for 2 counts. Breathe out through your mouth for 6 counts. Do this 3 to 5 times.

8

LISTEN TO MUSIC

Put on a song you love — a calm song or even a fun one. Music changes the chemicals in your brain and can shift your mood in just a few minutes.

My top 3 strategies I want to try:

2.2 — Deep Breathing Cards

Breathing is the fastest way to calm down. Here are four fun breathing techniques. Practice each one when you are calm so they are ready when you need them!

BALLOON BREATH

Imagine you are blowing up a balloon.

1. Put your hands on your belly.
2. Breathe in slowly through your nose — feel your belly fill up like a balloon (4 counts).
3. Hold for 2 counts.
4. Slowly breathe out through your mouth — feel the balloon deflate (6 counts).
5. Repeat 4 times.

SNAKE BREATH

Breathe out like a hissing snake.

1. Sit up straight and relax your shoulders.
2. Breathe in deeply through your nose (4 counts).
3. Breathe out very slowly through your mouth making a “ssssss” sound, as long as you can.
4. Try to make the hiss last longer each time.
5. Repeat 4 times.

BUNNY BREATH

Take quick little sniffs like a bunny.

1. Take 3 quick sniffs in through your nose (sniff, sniff, sniff).
2. Then one long, slow breath out through your mouth.
3. Wiggle your nose like a bunny between rounds.
4. Repeat 5 times.
5. This one is great when you need to calm down fast!

STAR BREATH

Trace a star while breathing.

1. Hold up one hand with fingers spread like a star.
2. Use the pointer finger of your other hand to trace up one finger — breathe in.
3. Trace down the other side — breathe out.
4. Continue up and down each finger until you have traced all five.
5. That is 5 complete breaths!

> **Pro Tip**
>
> Practice these breathing techniques every day for one week, even when you are not angry. That way, when anger arrives, your body will already know what to do!

2.3 — Counting Backwards Exercise

When anger hits, counting backwards forces your brain to focus on something other than the anger. Count from 10 to 1, and read the calming thought for each number. Take a slow breath between each one.

10	I notice I am feeling angry, and that is okay.
9	I am taking a deep breath right now. In through my nose...
8	...and out through my mouth. My shoulders are dropping.
7	I am unclenching my fists and letting my fingers relax.
6	I can feel my heartbeat starting to slow down.
5	Halfway there. I am doing a great job staying in control.
4	I am thinking of my safe, happy place right now.
3	This feeling will pass. Feelings always do.
2	I am strong enough to handle this situation.
1	I am calm, I am in control, and I can choose what to do next.

> **After You Reach 1**
>
> Ask yourself: *What is the smartest thing I can do right now?* Write it here:

2.4 — Safe Space Design Sheet

A **Safe Space** is a real or imaginary place where you can go to calm down. Design yours below! Think about a place that makes you feel peaceful and relaxed.

WHERE IS MY SAFE SPACE?

It can be a real place (your room, a corner, under a tree) or an imaginary one (a cloud, a beach, a treehouse).

WHAT IS IN MY SAFE SPACE?

Pillows? A favorite stuffed animal? Books? Music? Soft blankets? A stress ball?

WHAT DOES IT LOOK LIKE?

What colors? Is it bright or dim? Warm or cool? Draw or describe it.

WHO CAN BE THERE WITH ME?

Sometimes you need alone time. Sometimes a trusted person helps. Who is welcome?

WHAT DO I DO IN MY SAFE SPACE?

Breathe? Read? Listen to music? Squeeze something? Think happy thoughts?

DRAW MY SAFE SPACE

2.5 — Anger Iceberg Worksheet

An iceberg has a small part above the water and a much bigger part hidden underneath. Anger works the same way! The anger you show on the outside is often caused by *other feelings* hiding underneath. Let's explore what might be under your anger.

ANGER — what people see on the surface

Hidden feelings underneath — check the ones that sometimes hide under your anger:

☐ **Sad** — feeling hurt or like crying inside

☐ **Scared** — feeling afraid or worried about something

☐ **Embarrassed** — feeling like everyone is looking at you

☐ **Lonely** — feeling left out or all by yourself

☐ **Hurt** — feeling like someone did not care about you

☐ **Confused** — not understanding what is happening or why

☐ **Tired** — feeling exhausted, which makes everything worse

☐ **Hungry** — when your body needs food, feelings get bigger

Think about the last time you were really angry. What feelings were hiding underneath?

> **Why This Matters**
>
> When you can find the hidden feeling, you can solve the *real* problem. For example, if anger is hiding sadness, you might need a hug more than you need to yell.

3

Expressing Feelings

Find healthy ways to show what you feel inside

> *Keeping anger bottled up inside does not make it go away — it makes it bigger! In this section, you will learn lots of healthy ways to express your feelings: with words, with your body, and with art.*

3.1 — Feelings Vocabulary Cards

The more feeling words you know, the better you can explain what is happening inside you. Read each word and its meaning. When you know the right word for a feeling, the feeling becomes easier to handle.

Frustrated
Feeling upset because you cannot do something or things are not going your way. Like when a puzzle piece will not fit.

Anxious
Feeling worried or nervous about something that might happen. Like butterflies in your stomach before a test.

Overwhelmed
Feeling like there is too much happening at once and you cannot handle it. Like being in a room that is too loud.

Disappointed
Feeling let down because something you hoped for did not happen. Like when a play date gets canceled.

Jealous
Feeling upset because someone else has something you want. Like when a friend gets a toy you wished for.

Embarrassed
Feeling like everyone noticed something you did wrong. Like tripping in front of people. Your face might feel hot.

Lonely
Feeling like nobody is around or nobody understands you. Like eating lunch alone when everyone else has friends.

Guilty
Feeling bad because you did something you know was wrong. Like a heavy weight on your chest.

Hopeful
Feeling like things will get better. A warm, light feeling that good things are coming. This is a great feeling to aim for!

Proud
Feeling happy about something you accomplished. Like when you work hard and it pays off. Stand tall!

Grateful
Feeling thankful for something or someone in your life. Like a warm hug from the inside.

Calm
Feeling peaceful and relaxed. Your body is comfortable and your mind is quiet. This is the goal after anger!

3.2 — "I Feel… Because…" Sentence Starters

Using "I feel" sentences is one of the best ways to express anger without hurting anyone. Instead of saying "You are mean!" try saying "I feel hurt because you said that." Complete each sentence below.

I FEEL *ANGRY* BECAUSE…

I FEEL *FRUSTRATED* BECAUSE…

I FEEL *HURT* BECAUSE…

I FEEL *LEFT OUT* BECAUSE…

I FEEL *SCARED* BECAUSE...

I FEEL *JEALOUS* BECAUSE...

I FEEL *EMBARRASSED* BECAUSE...

I FEEL *PROUD* BECAUSE...

> **Practice**
> Try using one “I feel... because...” sentence every day this week, even for good feelings! The more you practice when you are calm, the easier it will be when you are angry.

3.3 — Emotion Charades Cards

Cut out these cards and play Emotion Charades! One person picks a card and acts out the emotion (no talking!). Everyone else guesses. This is a fun way to practice reading emotions in other people.

HAPPY

Big smile, bouncing around, clapping, laughing

ANGRY

Fists clenched, frown, stomping feet, crossed arms

SAD

Slumped shoulders, frowning, pretending to cry

SCARED

Wide eyes, hiding behind hands, shaking, stepping back

SURPRISED

Mouth open, eyebrows up, hands on cheeks, jumping

FRUSTRATED

Sighing, rubbing forehead, trying and failing at something

EMBARRASSED

Covering face, looking at floor, turning red, hiding

EXCITED

Jumping up and down, eyes wide, talking fast, waving arms

BORED

Yawning, resting chin on hand, looking around slowly

PROUD

Standing tall, hands on hips, big grin, chest puffed out

3.4 — Draw Your Anger Exercise

Art is a powerful way to express feelings without words. Use the boxes below to draw. There are no wrong answers — use any colors, shapes, or lines you want!

DRAW WHAT YOUR ANGER LOOKS LIKE

What color is it? What shape? Is it big or small? Does it have edges or is it smooth?

DRAW WHAT CALM LOOKS LIKE

How is it different from anger? What colors and shapes does calm use?

DRAW YOUR HAPPY PLACE

Where do you feel the most peaceful and safe? Draw it here.

3.5 — Letter to My Anger

Writing a letter to your anger might sound funny, but it really works! When you talk to your anger as if it were a visitor, you start to see that *you* are in charge — not the anger. Use the prompts below to write your letter.

DEAR ANGER,

WHEN YOU SHOW UP, I FEEL...

YOU VISIT ME MOST OFTEN WHEN...

I KNOW YOU ARE TRYING TO TELL ME...

BUT SOMETIMES YOU MAKE ME DO THINGS I REGRET, LIKE...

FROM NOW ON, WHEN YOU VISIT, I AM GOING TO...

I WANT YOU TO KNOW THAT I AM STRONGER THAN YOU BECAUSE...

Signed,

4

Problem Solving

Turn angry moments into learning moments

> *Once you have calmed down, it is time to solve the problem. Anger often shows up because of a conflict — a disagreement with another person. In this section, you will learn how to solve conflicts, make things right, and understand how other people feel.*

4.1 — Conflict Resolution Steps

When you have a conflict with someone, follow these five steps. Cut this page out or hang it on your wall so you can remember!

STOP & COOL DOWN

Before doing anything, take 3 deep breaths. Walk away if you need to. You cannot solve a problem when your brain is in “fire alarm” mode. Wait until you are at Level 2 or below on the Anger Intensity Scale.

SAY WHAT HAPPENED

Take turns explaining what happened. Each person gets a chance to talk without being interrupted. Use “I feel... because...” sentences. Stick to facts — no name-calling or blaming.

LISTEN TO UNDERSTAND

Really listen to the other person. Look at them, nod, and try to understand their point of view. Repeat back what you heard: “So you felt angry because you thought I was ignoring you?”

BRAINSTORM SOLUTIONS

Think of at least three possible solutions together. Do not judge the ideas yet — just come up with as many as you can. Write them down if it helps. Look for “win-win” ideas where both people get something they need.

AGREE & TRY IT

Pick the solution you both like best. Agree to try it. Shake hands or give a high-five. If it does not work, come back and try a different solution from your list. Problem-solving is a skill — it gets better with practice!

> **Remember**
>
> The goal is not to “win” the argument. The goal is to solve the problem so everyone feels better. That is real strength.

4.2 — Win-Win Solution Finder

A “win-win” solution is when both people get something they need. Use this template to work through a conflict. You can use it for a real problem or practice with an imaginary one.

THE PROBLEM IS...

Describe the conflict in a few sentences. What happened?

PERSON A WANTS...

What do YOU need?

PERSON B WANTS...

What does the OTHER person need?

THREE POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS:

1.

2.

3.

THE WIN-WIN SOLUTION WE CHOSE:

DID IT WORK? ☐ YES ☐ NO ☐ WE NEED TO TRY ANOTHER SOLUTION

4.3 — Apology Template

A good apology has three parts: saying what you did, why it was wrong, and what you will do differently. A real apology is not just saying “sorry” — it is showing that you understand and care. Fill in the blanks below.

My Apology

Dear _____,

I am sorry for

_____

_____

It was wrong because

_____

_____

I think it made you feel

_____

Next time, I will

_____

_____

I hope you can forgive me because

_____

Signed, _____

> **Pro Tip**
>
> Apologizing is not a sign of weakness — it is one of the bravest things you can do. It takes real courage to admit when you are wrong and try to make things right.

4.4 — Empathy Building Cards

Empathy means understanding how another person feels. Read each scenario below, then write how you think the person in the story feels and what you might do to help.

SCENARIO 1

Emma spent all week building a tower out of blocks. Her little brother accidentally knocked it over.

How would Emma feel?

What could you say to help?

SCENARIO 2

Marco invited all his classmates to his birthday party, but only two kids came.

How would Marco feel?

What could you do to help?

SCENARIO 3

Lily studied really hard for a test but still got a bad grade. She started crying at her desk.

How would Lily feel?

What could you say to help?

SCENARIO 4

Sam's best friend started playing with someone else at recess and told Sam to go away.

How would Sam feel?

What could you do to help?

SCENARIO 5

Ana accidentally broke her mom's favorite mug while trying to make her breakfast in bed.

How would Ana feel?

What could you say to help?

SCENARIO 6

Jake is new at school and does not know anyone. He sits alone at lunch every day.

How would Jake feel?

What could you do to help?

> **Remember**
>
> When you practice empathy, you build stronger friendships and have fewer conflicts. Try to think about how the other person feels before you react when you are angry!

My Anger Management Plan

Your personal toolkit — fill this out and keep it somewhere you can see it!

My Personal Anger Management Plan

You have learned so much! Now it is time to create your very own plan. Fill in each section using everything you have discovered about yourself in this workbook. Keep this page somewhere you can see it every day.

MY TOP 3 ANGER TRIGGERS

What makes me angry most often?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

MY BODY SIGNALS

How does my body tell me I am getting angry?

1. _____

2. _____

MY TOP 3 COOLING-DOWN STRATEGIES

What works best for me when I need to calm down?

1. _____

2. _____

3. _____

PEOPLE I CAN TALK TO

Trusted people who can help me when I am angry.

At home: _____

At school: _____

A friend: _____

MY GOAL

What do I want to get better at when it comes to anger?

_____

_____

MY PROMISE TO MYSELF

I, _____, promise to try my best to recognize my anger, use my cooling-down strategies, express my feelings with words, and solve problems without hurting myself or others.

Signed: _____ **Date:** _____

Next Step

Congratulations on completing **Managing Anger for Kids**! You now have an incredible set of tools to help you understand, express, and control your big emotions.

Remember: managing anger is a *skill*, not a talent. Just like learning to ride a bike or play an instrument, it takes practice. Some days will be easier than others, and that is perfectly normal.

Keep your Anger Management Plan where you can see it. Practice your breathing techniques every day. Use your “I feel... because...” sentences. And most importantly, be kind to yourself on the days when anger gets the best of you. Tomorrow is always a new chance to try again.

You are brave. You are strong. You are in control.

NeuroKids™